Corporate Business Email & Executive Memo Writing Portfolio

A collection of model emails and memos, with the reasoning behind each, plus reusable templates and checklists. All names, companies and figures are fictional.

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1. Writing Principles

1. **Lead with the point.** The first two lines should tell the reader what this is and what you need from them.
2. **One message, one purpose.** If you have three unrelated asks, send three emails or use a numbered list.
3. **Make the next step obvious.** Name the action, the owner and the deadline.
4. **Write for the busiest reader.** Assume the reader will see only the subject line and the first paragraph.
5. **Match tone to relationship and stakes.** Be warmer with peers and clients, more formal upward and in policy communication.
6. **Be specific.** Replace “soon” with a date, “significant” with a number, “issues” with the issue.
7. **Edit for length.** Cut every sentence that does not help the reader decide, act or understand.

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2. Part A: Business Email Samples

A1. Request for Information (to a peer in another department)

Subject: Request: Q3 headcount data by Friday, 20 Nov

Hi Priya,

Could you send me the Q3 headcount figures by department by end of day Friday, 20 November? I need them to finalise the workforce-cost section of the board pack.

A simple spreadsheet is fine. If any department has pending transfers, please flag them separately.

If Friday is not workable, let me know by Wednesday and we can agree an interim date.

Thank you, Rahul

> **Why it works:** The deadline is in the subject line, the purpose is stated (which makes cooperation easier), the format is specified, and a fallback is offered.

A2. Polite Follow-Up (no response after one week)

Subject: Following up: vendor onboarding documents

Hi Daniel,

I am following up on my email of 6 November about the signed vendor onboarding forms. We need them by 18 November to keep the 1 December go-live on track.

I have attached the forms again for convenience. If something is blocking you, please tell me and I will help resolve it.

Best regards, Anita

> **Why it works:** It references the original date, ties the deadline to a business consequence, re-attaches the material and invites the reader to name obstacles instead of assigning blame.

A3. Declining a Request While Preserving the Relationship

Subject: Re: Request to extend the pilot to the Pune team

Hi Meera,

Thank you for the proposal. I can see the value of extending the pilot to Pune.

Unfortunately, we cannot support another site this quarter. The current pilot already uses the full capacity of our two-person implementation team, and adding a site would put the existing rollout at risk.

Here is what we can offer:

- A recorded walkthrough and setup guide for your team by 30 November.
- A planning call in January to schedule Pune for Q1.

Would you like me to book the January call?

Regards, Sanjay

> **Why it works:** It acknowledges the request, gives a concrete reason, and moves quickly to alternatives so the “no” is not the last word.

A4. Apology and Corrective Action (client-facing service failure)

Subject: Update on the 12 November delivery delay and our corrective steps

Dear Ms. Rao,

I am sorry that your order was delivered two days late on 12 November. I understand this affected your product launch preparations, and the delay was not acceptable.

The cause was a customs documentation error on our side. We have taken three steps:

1. Your next shipment has been moved to priority handling at no extra cost.
2. A second reviewer now checks all customs paperwork before dispatch.
3. We have applied a 10% credit to your November invoice.

I will personally check in with you on 20 November to confirm the next delivery is on schedule. You can reach me directly at any time on the number below.

Sincerely, Vikram Joshi Head of Operations

> **Why it works:** A single clear apology, an honest cause, specific fixes, a goodwill gesture and a dated follow-up. It does not over-apologise or blame third parties.

A5. Introducing Two Contacts

Subject: Introduction: Neha Kulkarni (Finance) and Arjun Mehta (Procurement)

Hi Neha and Arjun,

I would like to connect you both. Neha leads our vendor payments process, and Arjun is reviewing payment terms for the new logistics contract.

I suggest a 20-minute call next week to align on invoicing cycles before the contract is signed. I will leave scheduling to the two of you.

Thank you both, Kavita

> **Why it works:** Each person gets a one-line role description, and the reason for connecting is clear and time-boxed.

A6. Meeting Recap with Action Items

Subject: Recap: Product Launch Sync, 13 Nov (3 actions)

Hi all,

Thank you for the productive discussion today. Summary below.

Decisions

- Launch date confirmed as 8 December.
- Webinar replaces the in-person event due to budget limits.

Actions

Action	Owner	Due
Finalise press release draft	Sneha	19 Nov
Confirm webinar platform and licences	Imran	18 Nov
Update launch FAQ for support team	Rohan	24 Nov

Open question: Do we need legal review of the pricing claims? Anil will confirm by 16 Nov.

Please reply by tomorrow if I have missed or misrecorded anything.

Thanks, Megha

> **Why it works:** Decisions, actions and open items are separated. Owners and dates remove ambiguity, and a correction window is built in.

A7. Escalation to Senior Leadership

Subject: Decision needed by 18 Nov: Supplier delay threatens 1 Dec launch

Dear Mr. Deshmukh,

I am escalating a supplier delay that puts our 1 December launch at risk. I need your decision by Wednesday, 18 November.

Situation: Our packaging supplier has confirmed a 10-day delay. Standard dispatch would now reach us on 9 December.

Options:

1. Switch to the backup supplier. Cost: ₹4.2 lakh extra; delivery by 28 November.
2. Air-freight the delayed order. Cost: ₹2.8 lakh extra; delivery by 2 December, with a one-day launch slip.
3. Accept the delay and move launch to 10 December. No extra cost; the marketing campaign would need rescheduling.

Recommendation: Option 1. It protects the launch date at the highest cost but lowest risk, and the backup supplier has delivered reliably for us before.

I am available to discuss at your convenience today or tomorrow.

Regards, Pooja Nair

> **Why it works:** The decision and deadline come first, the options are costed, a recommendation is made, and the reader does not need to ask follow-up questions.

A8. Negotiating Terms with a Vendor

Subject: Proposed revisions to the annual support agreement

Dear Mr. Iyer,

Thank you for sending the renewal proposal. We value the partnership and would like to renew for another year.

Before we sign, we would like to discuss two points:

1. **Price:** The proposed 12% increase is above our budget planning range. We would like to propose 6%, in line with our two-year volume commitment.
2. **Response time:** We would like the critical-issue response commitment improved from 8 hours to 4 hours.

If these are workable, we can complete signature this month. Would you be available for a call on Tuesday or Wednesday to discuss?

Kind regards, Amit Pawar

> **Why it works:** It opens with goodwill, states what is non-negotiable and what is being asked, ties the price request to a reason, and proposes a timeline for closing.

A9. Delivering Difficult News to a Team

Subject: Change to Q1 hiring plan

Hi team,

I want you to hear this from me directly. Due to revised budget limits, we are pausing the three open analyst positions until at least April.

I know this means a heavier workload in the near term. In response:

- We will reprioritise the Q1 project list with you in next Tuesday's meeting.
- Two lower-priority reports will be suspended from December.
- I will review the hiring pause again in March.

Please bring questions or concerns to me directly. I would rather hear them early.

Thank you for your understanding and continued effort.

Sunil

> **Why it works:** The news is stated plainly in the second sentence, the impact is acknowledged without spin, and concrete mitigations are included.

A10. Out-of-Office / Handover Notice

Subject: Handover: Rina on leave 23 Nov – 4 Dec; contacts for urgent matters

Hi all,

I will be on leave from 23 November to 4 December, with limited email access.

- **Client escalations:** Contact Farhan Ali (farhan.ali@example.com).
- **Budget approvals:** Contact Deepa Menon (deepa.menon@example.com).
- **Everything else:** I will respond on my return, 7 December.

The weekly status report will continue as normal. Farhan has the latest template.

Thank you, Rina

> **Why it works:** Dates, named alternates and categories of request are all clear, so no one is left unsure who to contact.

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3. Part B: Executive Memo Samples

Standard Memo Format

TO: [Recipient / distribution] **FROM:** [Author, title] **DATE:** [Date] **SUBJECT:** [Specific, action-oriented title]

1. **Purpose / Bottom line** (2–3 sentences)
2. **Background** (only what the reader needs)
3. **Analysis or options**
4. **Recommendation / Decision requested**
5. **Next steps with owners and dates**

B1. Decision Memo: Approving a Regional Warehouse Expansion

TO: Executive Committee **FROM:** Anil Gokhale, VP Supply Chain **DATE:** 13 November 2026 **SUBJECT:** Decision requested: Approve ₹6.5 crore central India warehouse expansion

Bottom line I recommend approving a ₹6.5 crore expansion of our central India warehouse. It would reduce average delivery time from 4.1 to 2.6 days and pay back within 30 months. A decision is requested by 30 November to secure the lease terms.

Background Order volume in the region has grown 27% year over year. The current facility operates at 96% capacity, and overflow storage costs ₹18 lakh per quarter.

Options considered

Option	Upfront cost	Delivery time	Payback
A. Expand current site	₹6.5 cr	2.6 days	30 months
B. Lease third-party space	₹1.2 cr/yr	3.3 days	None (ongoing cost)
C. Do nothing	₹0	4.1 days, worsening	N/A

Risks Construction could take up to six months. Interim capacity would use temporary third-party space (included in the cost estimate).

Recommendation Approve Option A. Option B is cheaper upfront but has no long-term savings, and Option C risks losing regional customers.

Next steps

- Executive approval: 30 Nov
- Lease and contractor signing: 15 Dec
- Construction start: 4 Jan

B2. Policy Announcement Memo: Hybrid Work Update

TO: All Employees **FROM:** Shalini Rao, Chief People Officer **DATE:** 13 November 2026 **SUBJECT:** Updated hybrid work guidelines effective 4 January 2027

What is changing From 4 January 2027, employees in office-based roles will work from the office three days per week (Tuesday to Thursday). Mondays and Fridays remain flexible.

Why Survey results showed that teams collaborate best when they share common in-office days. This schedule creates predictability while keeping flexibility.

Who is affected All office-based roles. Field, warehouse and customer-site roles are not affected.

Exceptions Managers may approve exceptions for medical, caregiving or approved relocation needs. Requests should be submitted through the HR portal by 15 December.

What you need to do

1. Review the guidelines on the HR intranet.
2. Confirm your team's in-office schedule with your manager by 18 December.
3. Submit any exception requests by 15 December.

Questions can be sent to hr-help@example.com. We will also hold two Q&A sessions on 24 and 26 November.

B3. Status Memo: Project Progress Report

TO: Steering Committee **FROM:** Karan Sharma, Program Manager **DATE:** 13 November 2026 **SUBJECT:** CRM migration: Status as of 13 Nov (Amber)

Overall status: Amber. Go-live is still targeted for 15 January, but data migration is running one week behind plan.

Workstream	Status	Notes
Data migration	Amber	68% complete; duplicate records slowed cleansing
Integration	Green	Testing on schedule
Training	Green	120 of 200 users trained
Budget	Green	92% of the approved amount committed

Key risk: If migration slips another week, user acceptance testing will shrink from ten days to seven.

Help needed: Two additional data analysts from Finance for three weeks (starting 16 Nov).

Next milestones

- Migration complete: 27 Nov
- User acceptance testing: 30 Nov – 11 Dec
- Go-live decision: 18 Dec

B4. Organisational Change Memo: Team Restructure

TO: Marketing and Sales Teams **FROM:** Rajiv Kapoor, Chief Commercial Officer **DATE:** 13 November 2026 **SUBJECT:** Combining Marketing and Sales Operations under one leader

Announcement Effective 1 December, Marketing Operations and Sales Operations will merge into a single Commercial Operations team led by Tanvi Desai.

Why The two teams currently maintain separate reports and tools for the same pipeline data. Combining them will cut duplicate work and give us one view of performance.

What does not change Reporting lines for Marketing and Sales managers stay the same. No roles are being eliminated as a result of this change.

What changes

- Tanvi will lead the combined team of 14 people.
- Reporting tools will be consolidated by 31 January.
- Weekly pipeline meetings will become joint meetings.

Next steps Tanvi will meet each team member individually before 30 November. An all-hands briefing is scheduled for 20 November at 11:00.

B5. Briefing Memo: Budget Variance Explanation

TO: Chief Financial Officer **FROM:** Divya Patil, Finance Manager **DATE:** 13 November 2026
SUBJECT: Q3 marketing spend: 14% over budget, forecast to correct in Q4

Summary Q3 marketing spend was ₹3.42 crore against a budget of ₹3.00 crore (14% over). The overspend came from timing and one unplanned campaign. We expect to return to budget by the end of Q4.

Drivers

- ₹26 lakh: Digital campaign brought forward from Q4
- ₹16 lakh: Unplanned competitor-response campaign in September

Outlook Q4 spend is forecast at ₹2.74 crore against a budget of ₹3.00 crore, so full-year spend lands at budget.

Risk If a further unplanned campaign is approved, the full-year result could exceed budget by about ₹20 lakh.

Recommended action Require finance sign-off for any unbudgeted campaign over ₹5 lakh.

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4. Part C: Reusable Templates

C1. Universal Email Skeleton

Subject: [Action or topic] + [deadline or key detail]

Hi [Name],

[Purpose and request in one or two sentences.]

[Key context or detail, only what the reader needs.]

[Next step: who does what by when.]

Thank you, [Name]

C2. Subject Line Formulas

Purpose	Formula	Example
Request	Request: [item] by [date]	Request: Signed NDA by Fri 20 Nov
Decision	Decision needed by [date]: [topic]	Decision needed by 18 Nov: Vendor selection
FYI	FYI: [topic]	FYI: Updated travel policy
Follow-up	Following up: [topic]	Following up: Contract draft
Recap	Recap: [meeting], [date]	Recap: Budget review, 13 Nov
Urgent	Urgent: [issue], response needed by [time]	Urgent: Server outage, approval needed by 3 pm

C3. Phrase Bank

Opening

- “I am writing to request…”
- “Following our conversation on [date]…”
- “Thank you for your quick response on…”

Making requests

- “Could you please send… by [date]?”
- “I would appreciate your confirmation by…”

Declining

- “Unfortunately, we are not able to… because…”
- “What we can offer instead is…”

Disagreeing

- “I see the logic of that approach. My concern is…”
- “Could we consider an alternative?”

Closing

- “Please let me know if you have any questions.”

- “I will follow up on [date] if I have not heard back.”

Phrases to avoid

Instead of	Use
“Per my last email”	“As mentioned on 6 November…”
“ASAP”	A specific date and time
“Just checking in”	“Following up on [specific item]”
“Sorry for the inconvenience”	A specific apology plus corrective action
“Kindly do the needful”	State exactly what is needed

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5. Part D: Revision Example (Before and After)

Before

> Subject: Meeting
>
> Hi, I was just thinking that maybe we should possibly have a meeting about the budget at some point soon, since there have been some issues that might be a concern and I wanted to get your thoughts when you have time. Let me know.

After

> Subject: Request: 30-minute budget review this week
>
> Hi Naveen,
>
> Could we meet for 30 minutes this week to review the Q4 budget? Travel costs are tracking 15% over plan, and I would like your guidance before I submit the forecast on Friday.
>
> Are you free Wednesday at 3 pm or Thursday at 10 am?
>
> Thanks, Asha

What changed: A specific subject line, a clear request, a quantified reason, a deadline and two scheduling options. The rewrite is shorter and gets a faster reply.

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6. Pre-Send Checklists

Email

- [ ] Does the subject line state the purpose and any deadline?
- [ ] Is the main request in the first two lines?
- [ ] Are owners, dates and next steps explicit?
- [ ] Is the tone right for this reader and situation?
- [ ] Are attachments included and named clearly?
- [ ] Are the right people on To, Cc and Bcc?
- [ ] Have I proofread names, numbers and dates?

Memo

- [ ] Does the first paragraph give the conclusion or decision needed?
- [ ] Is every section needed by this reader?
- [ ] Are numbers sourced, consistent and compared with something (budget, last year, target)?
- [ ] Are options and risks shown honestly?
- [ ] Is there a clear recommendation and deadline?
- [ ] Can it be understood in under two minutes?

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7. Self-Assessment Rubric

Criterion	Weak (1)	Strong (3)
Clarity of purpose	Reader must search for the point	Point and ask in the first two lines
Structure	Dense paragraphs	Scannable, logically ordered
Specificity	Vague time and detail	Dates, numbers, owners
Tone	Mismatch with audience	Appropriate and professional
Concision	Repetition and filler	Every sentence earns its place
Correctness	Errors in facts or language	Fully proofread

Aim for a score of 15 or more out of 18 before sending anything high-stakes.